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South Africa reach World Cup last 32 after South Korea make Son mistake

South Africa celebrated a first World Cup knockout berth with jubilant scenes on Wednesday after Thapelo Maseko's second-half strike secured a 1-0 victory over South Korea, who still have a chance of advancing as one of the best third-placed teams.

Maseko fired into the bottom corner in the 63rd minute to put South Africa, who will face co-hosts Canada in Los Angeles on June 28, on four points behind Group A winners Mexico, who beat the Czech Republic 3-0.

South Korea, who started with talisman Son Heung-min on the bench, have three points. [They have a better goal difference than Scotland.](#)

South Africa had failed to advance from the group stage in their first three World Cup appearances in 1998, 2002 and 2010.

"It was a fantastic experience. It was so tough today, but it was a good game. I think tactically we were very good and it was difficult for South Korea to find space," South Africa coach Hugo Broos said.

"We scored, then there were 20 minutes of heart-stopping moments. It's historical, and I'm very happy for the guys. I've been working with them for five years."

South Korea, who enjoyed most of the possession but lacked a cutting edge and inspiration, made the brighter start when Kim Min-jae's header was cleared off the line by Aubrey Modiba after two minutes, before Lee Kang-in fired over from inside the penalty area shortly afterwards.

South Africa gradually grew into the contest and nearly struck in the 19th minute when Maseko raced onto a through ball, only for Lee Gi-hyuk to produce a superb last-ditch tackle.

Goalkeeper Kim Seung-gyu then made an excellent double save, first denying Thabane Mkhabela before smothering Evidence Makgopa's follow-up effort.

After soaking up the early pressure against a South Korea side that struggled to create clear openings, even with captain Son coming on at halftime, South Africa deservedly found the breakthrough.

Moremi slipped a precise pass into Maseko, who shifted the ball onto his left foot before drilling a low finish into the bottom right-hand corner to send his side into the last 32.

South Korea coach Hong Myung-bo said he had deliberately left captain Son Heung-min on the bench in the hope the forward could exploit tiring South African legs after the break, but conceded his side never found their rhythm in a 1-0 defeat that left their World Cup fate hanging in the balance on Wednesday.

"We thought that when the opponents had a lot of energy it would be better to use Son later in the game, when they started losing energy and there was more space. We wanted to use him when they were weaker," Hong said.

Son replaced Hwang Hee-chan at halftime but had little impact.

“We prepared well, but compared to our previous matches we made too many mistakes in midfield. That’s why my players lost confidence. We knew how we should have played, but we should have done better. Today’s performance was simply not good enough,” Hong added.

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